

Emergence of Bangladesh

North South University

Dhaka, Bangladesh

HIS 103

THE COLONIAL PLUNDERING OF BENGAL RESOURCES

DHP, NSU

Faculty Initial: SaMS

HIS 103, Office: NAC 1031

Defining Colonialism:

- Colonialism refers to the combination of territorial, juridical, cultural, linguistic, political, mental/epistemic, and/or economic domination of one group of people or groups of people by another (external) group of people (Murrey, 2020).
- Control over land, labor, culture and imagined geographies
- Territorial domination and land dispossession
- Colonial matrix of power

HISTORICAL BACKGROUND :

- The dawn of the 18th century witnessed a **booming economy in the Kingdom of Bengal** at a time when the BEIM was trying to consolidate its business across the region.
- Being impressed by its abundance of Bengal, Mughal Emperor Humayun once regarded Bengal as Zannat-abad or habitat paradise. Same way every Mughal official *formans* mentioned Bengal as the 'Paradise of India'. Recognizing the superiority of the region, Ghulam Hussain Salim in his Persian text *Riyaz-us-Salatin* described Bengal as Zannat-al-bilad or 'Paradise of Nations'. Long before the British rule was established in Bengal, a travelling Englishman also noted in his diary that : **"A wonderful land, whose richness and abundance neither war, persilence nor oppression could destroy"**.

- Bengal had been traditionally an exporting country.
- Within half a century of company rule **Bengal lost its predominance** in the export market. Gradually it was turned into a captive market for British industrial products and an agricultural hinterland for the supply of agricultural raw materials to the metropolitan manufactories.

FOREIGN TRADE STATISTICS:

TABLE 3.1 Foreign trade, 1874–99 (in millions of rupees)

<i>Quinquennial Average</i>	<i>Exports</i>	<i>Imports</i>	<i>Excess Export</i>
1874–79	630	380	250
1879–84	790	590	200
1884–89	880	610	270
1889–94	1,040	710	330
1894–99	1,070	740	330

Source: M.N. Roy, *The Future of India's Politics* (London: R. Bishop, n.d.), p. 14.

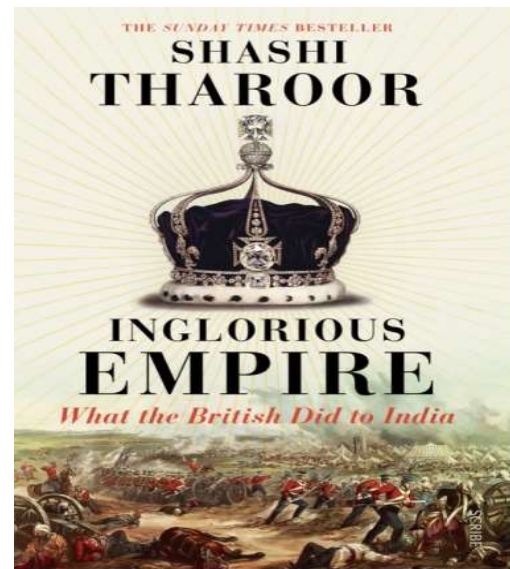
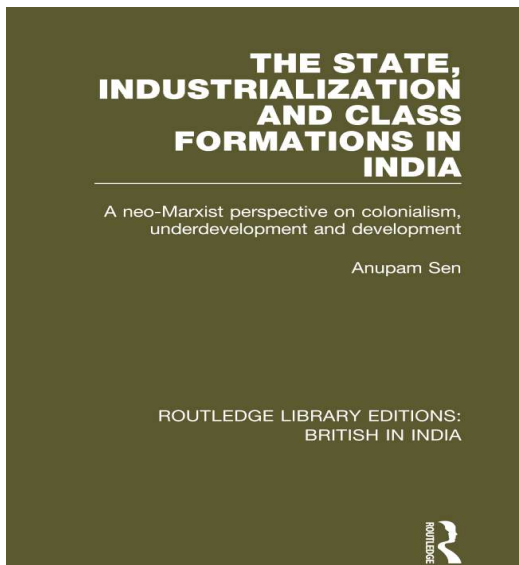
ACCESS EXPORTS SERVING THE COLONIAL PURPOSE :

India's imports were always less than her exports. This favorable balance of trade, however, did not indicate India's growing prosperity. The excess exports were always siphoned off to England to serve the imperial cause.

To quash colonial misdeeds, the colonialist writers generally argued that unlike other colonial powers the British helped their colonies to grow and develop in terms of Western education, legal system, culture, leadership, constitutionalism, agriculture, infrastructural development, industrialization and so on. Angus Maddison in his book entitled, *Class Structure and Economic Growth : India and Pakistan since the Moghuls* demonstrated many positive aspects of the British rule in the Indian sub-continent. He argued that the key motivation for the British rule in Bengal was economic.

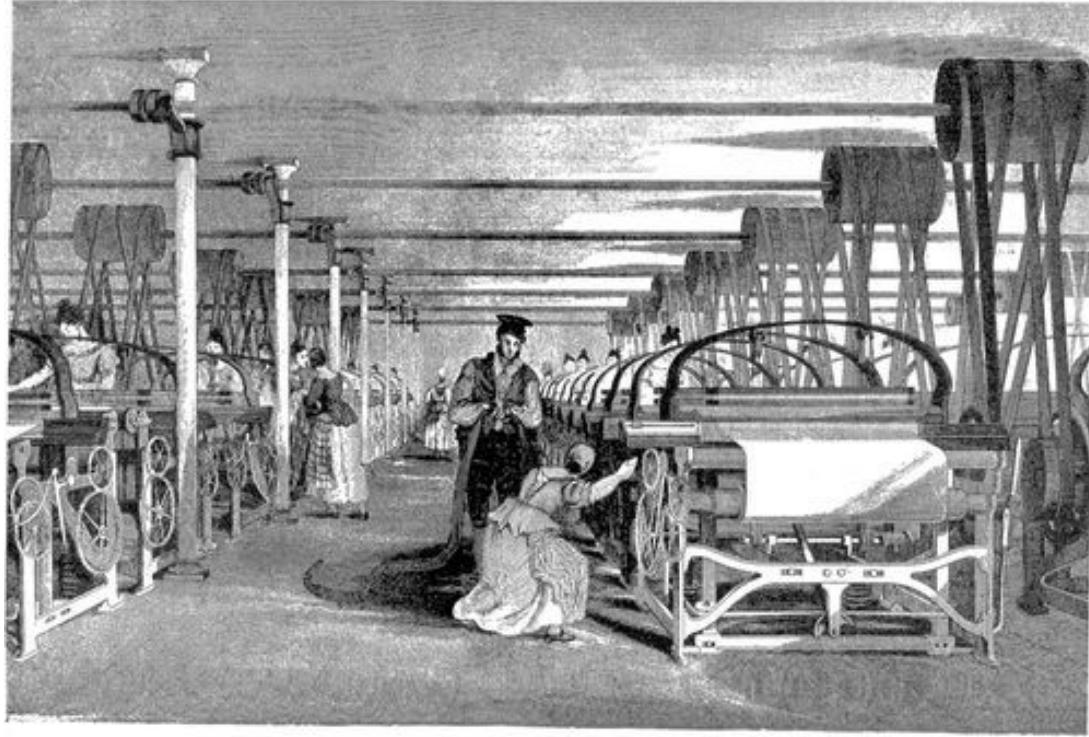
Discussions :

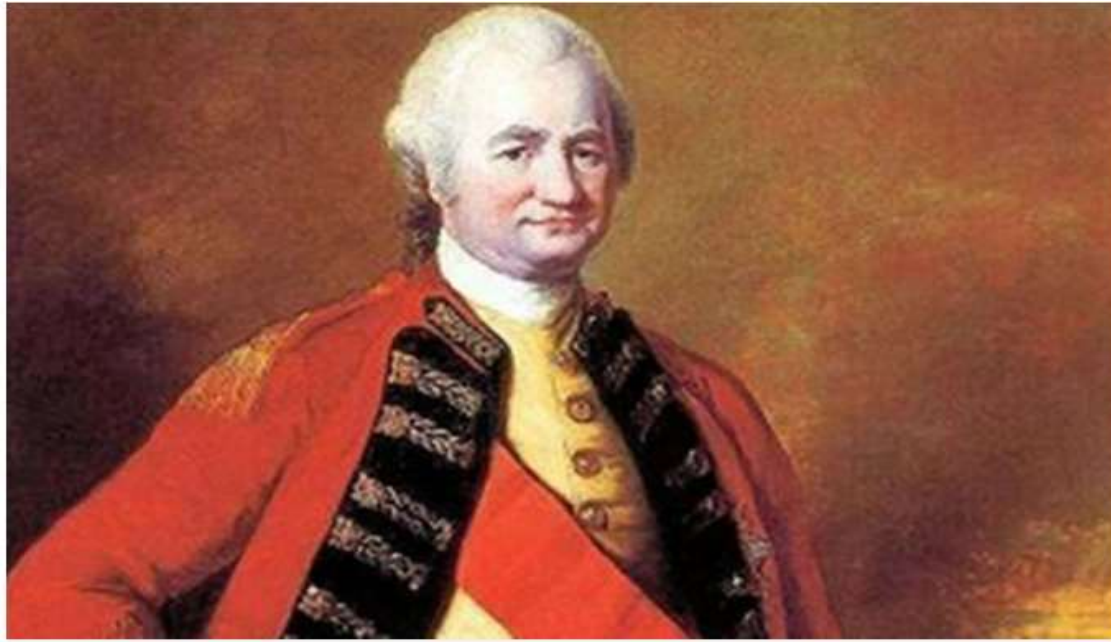
- Professor Anupam Sen in his book entitled, *The State, Industrialization and Class Formations in India*, provided an analysis of **the questionable impact** of the colonial state in bringing **under-development** in the Indian sub-continent.



- The victory of British power in 1757 killed **indigenous capitalism** in its nascent stage.
- The trade which was being carried on by the East India Company, and for which England had to pay huge amounts of billion to Indian traders and manufacturers, was transformed into '**organized plunder**'.
- The British authority steadily started the plundering of Bengal **resources right from day one (Haq, 2019)**.

- The plunder of Bengal resources helped **capital formation in England** on an **unprecedented scale** and ushered in the **INDUSTRIAL REVOLUTION**.
- Developments of technology, machine , factories, industries, rails, roads and markets





*The accumulation of wealth dominated the life and mysterious death of Lord Clive of India, writes **Chris Upton**.*

Looting/plundering of resources from the Indian Subcontinent :

- A House of Commons report indicated the following amount of the looting of Bengal resources as prize money from Murshidabad, the capital of Kingdom of Bengal:

Name	Received Amount
Governor Drake	Rs. 4,80,000/-
Watts	Rs. 12,40,000/-
Mir Jafar	Rs.16,00,000/-
Lord Clive	Rs. 25,00, 000/-

- 100 ships loaded with Bengal resources and treasuries sailed for Clive to London and this sort of plundering continued during his two subsequent visits.
- Eventually Robert Clive had to face **corruption charges** and received his **life-long imprisonment** for siphoning off wealth to his personal account.
- To evade him and disgrace, Clive later on **committed suicide** behind the bar.

Clive's father followed his son's career in India closely, recognizing that the family's fortunes depended on Indian loot. 'As your conduct and bravery is become the publick [*sic*] talk of the nation,' he wrote to his son in 1752, 'this is the time to increase your fortune, make use of the present opportunity before you quit the Country.'" He did, buying his father and himself seats in Parliament, and acquiring a peerage (it was only in Ireland, so he renamed his County Clare estate 'Plassey'.) The Whig politician and author Horace Walpole wrote: 'Here was Lord Clive's diamond house; this is Leadenhall Street, and this broken column was part of the palace of a company of merchants who were sovereigns of Bengal! They starved millions in India by monopolies and plunder, and almost raised a famine at home by the luxury occasioned by their opulence, and by that opulence raising the prices of everything, till the poor could not purchase bread!'

- The plundering was so **merciless** that even the English-appointed Bengali Nawab protested to the Company's governor in Calcutta in the following ways:

*“They **forcibly** take away goods and commodities of the ryots, merchants, etc., for a fourth of their value; and by ways of **violence and oppression**, they oblige the ryots, etc., to give five rupees for goods which are worth but one rupee” (Sen,2017).*

It is impossible to state exactly how much India had been **drained** since the battle of Plassey in 1757. According to W. Digby:

*“Estimates have been made which vary from 500,000,000 pounds to nearly **1,000,000,000 pounds**. Probably between Plassey and Waterloo the last mentioned sum was **transferred** from Indian hoards **to the English Bank**” (Sen, 2017).*

British capitalists, for the extraction of raw materials and commercial penetration, had to **invest** in railways, tea, coffee, jute, coal, iron ore, and other mining industries. British capital was mainly invested in those areas of the Indian economy which did not come into conflict with metropolitan industrial interests, and was **confined to such enterprises as railways, coal mines, jute mills, tea, coffee and sugar plantations – industries related to the production and export of raw materials**. Moreover, the influx of the Bengal capital in the UK industries was **fabulous**.

- A cash cow is referred to a company or an asset or a business unit that provides a consistent stream of cash flows by capturing large market share and requires a **relatively lower amount of capital investment and maintenance cost**. Products generated through the assets are standard and have a consistent growth of demand and therefore, provide **higher returns at a lower risk**.
- During the initial years of the Industrial Revolution , for nearly 50 years , Great Britain remained without a competitor overseas and **could use Bengal as the biggest ‘cash cow’ in their exploitative mission**. In order to create and expand their external market, the BEIC **destroyed** the local cotton and textile industries including the famous *Muslin* products in Eastern Bengal.
- The Bengal raw silk , cloths etc. to a vast amount were exported to the West. In an attempt to feed their own new textile products, the colonial government through **various methods of oppression** to the poor weavers such as **by fines, imprisonments, flogging, forcing bonds** from them **systematically** destroyed the domestic industry.

- In connection to the *Industrial Revolution*, the expanding British textile industry needed a steady supply of **indigo** from Bengal. As a result of the British government initiatives and policies, the economic hardship of the ordinary farmers and citizen increased.
- Textiles were an emblematic case in point: the British **systematically set about destroying India's textile manufacturing and exports**, substituting Indian textiles by British ones manufactured in England. Ironically, the British used Indian raw material and exported the **finished products back to India** and the rest of the world, the industrial equivalent of adding insult to injury. **The British destruction of textile competition from India led to the first great deindustrialization(Tharoor,2017).**

Dr. Shashi Tharoor's *Oxford Union* Address on British Colonial Plundering :



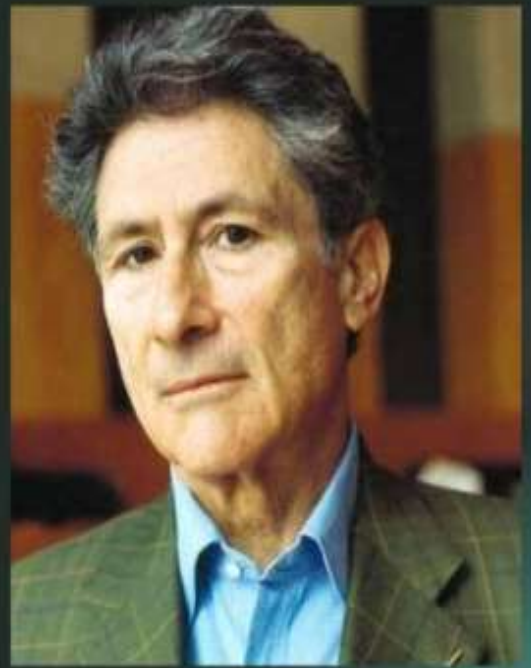
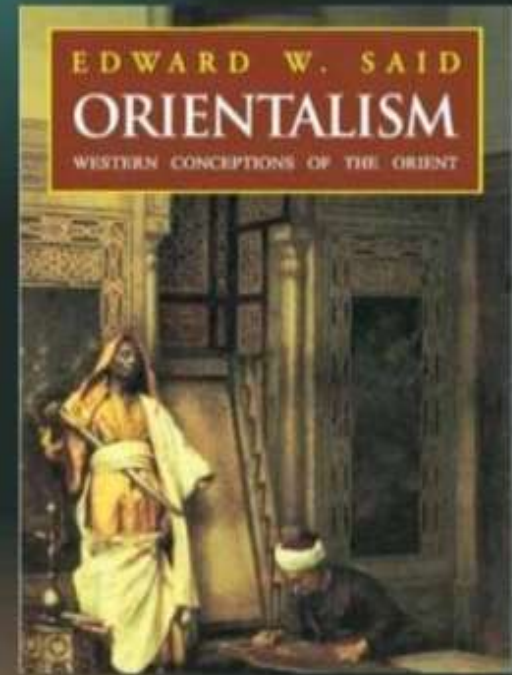
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=f7CW7S0zxv4>

Two main objectives of the colonial government:

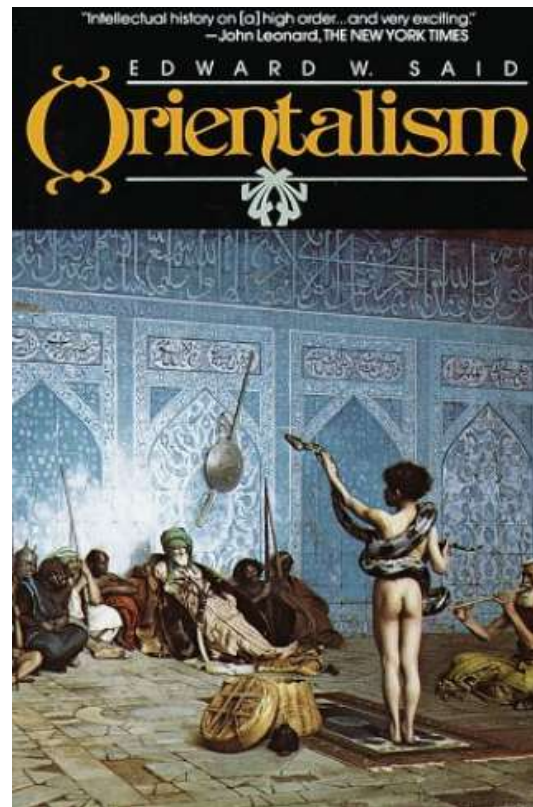
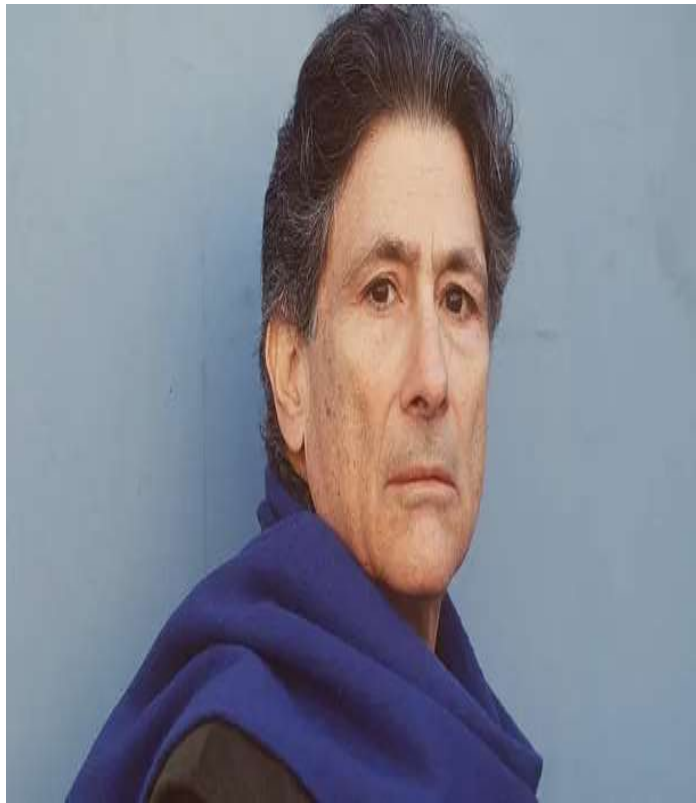
1. Timely collection of revenues
2. Law and order maintenance

Colonial Legacy:

Capitalist development in Pakistan has taken place under their **corrupt patronage and close control by the bureaucracy**. Because of bureaucratic controls, business opportunities have been restricted to a **privileged few** who have established the necessary relationship with the bureaucracy, essentially based on the **cash nexus** (**Hamza Alavi**, *The State in Postcolonial Societies*, p.69)



- The Orient is an integral part of European material civilization and culture. Orientalism expresses and represents that part culturally and even ideologically as a mode of discourse with **supporting institutions, vocabulary, scholarship, imagery, doctrines, even colonial bureaucracies and colonial styles** (Said, *Orientalism*, p.2)
- Orientalism as a **Western style for dominating, restructuring, and having authority over the Orient.**
- European culture gained its strength and identity by setting itself off against the Orient.
- Cultural domination, image-making
- The nexus of **power** and **knowledge** creating the “orient”/the colonized people/ otherness or othering (“We” versus “they”)



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